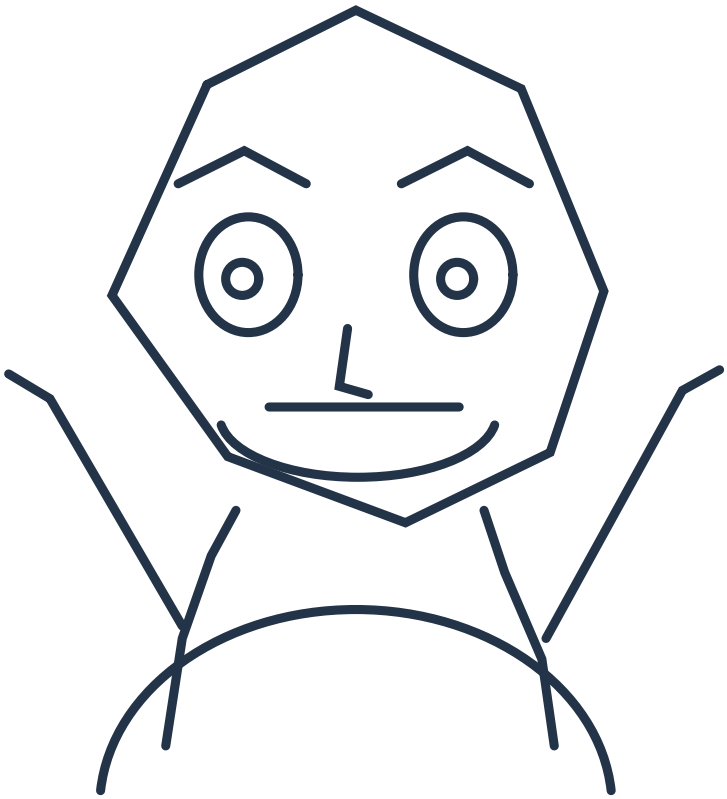
A DRAWING COURSE FOR KIDS

How to Draw Faces & Feelings

30 expressions / 90 variations / 10 story scenes



A face gives clues. A pose gives more.

Heath Tolley

START HERE

A face is a clue

Look

Notice the eyebrows, eyes, and mouth.

Look again

A pose and setting can change what the face means.

Ask

We cannot know exactly what someone feels just by looking.

Draw

Use the clues, then make a character with a story.

Many feelings can be mixed. Every person shows them differently.

WARM-UP 1

The expression toolkit

EYEBROWS

Try two high, two low, and one uneven pair.

EYES

Try wide, narrow, looking aside, and closed.

MOUTHS

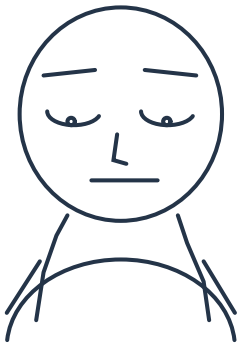
Try a smile, an O, a flat line, and a frown.

POSTURE

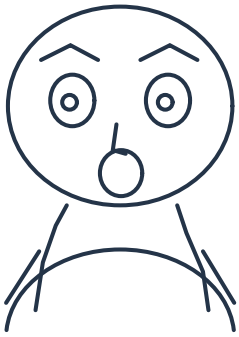
Draw shoulders raised, dropped, open, and turned away.

WARM-UP 2

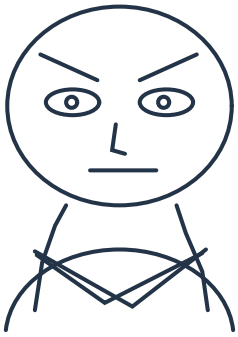
Change one clue



Calm



Surprised



Angry

Try keeping the eyes but changing only the mouth.

Then keep the mouth but change the brows.

Which change was easiest for you to recognize?

WARM-UP 3

Your practice plan

Lessons 01-10: begin with easy-to-read expressions.

Lessons 11-20: draw quieter or mixed clues.

Lessons 21-30: add action, posture, and context.

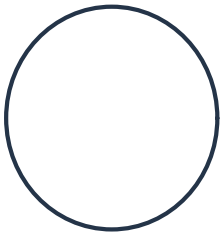
Story scenes: combine two people and a cause for each feeling.

Draw with a pencil first. Keep the sketch lines light.

Calm

The rain taps the window while Maya reads.

1 Head outline



2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



DRAWING CLUE

Show a quiet smile and shoulders at rest.

Calm: three strengths

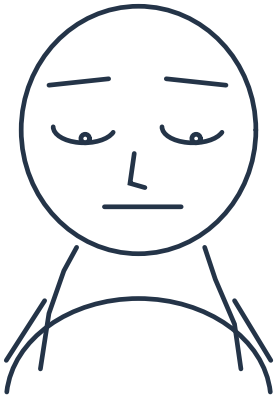
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



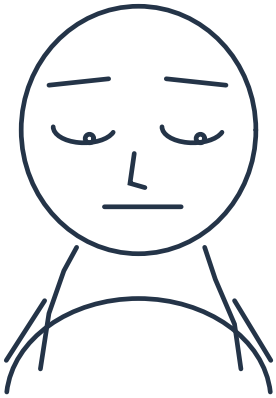
Brow: relaxed.

Easy to see



Mouth: easy breath.

Strong



Show a quiet smile and shoulders at rest.

IN THIS STORY

The rain taps the window while Maya reads.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I feel settled and ready to listen."

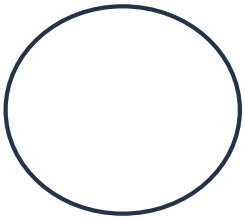
YOUR TURN

Calm can be quiet without being happy. Draw another cause for this feeling.

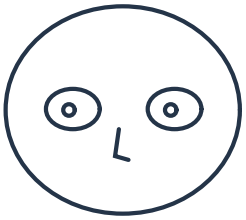
Joyful

Sam sees his friend return after a long trip.

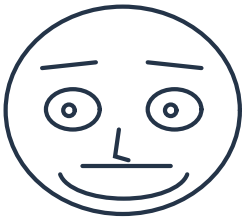
1 Head outline



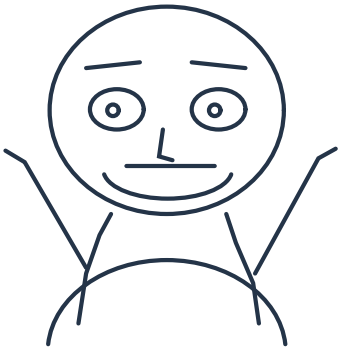
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



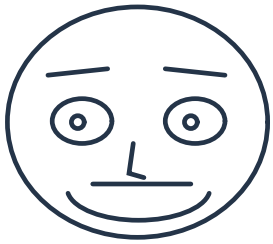
DRAWING CLUE

Lift the cheeks; open both arms.

Joyful: three strengths

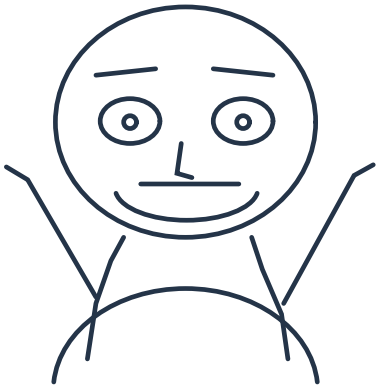
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



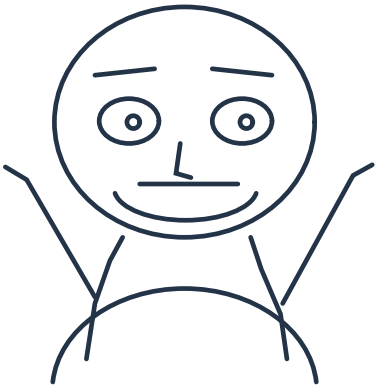
Brow: lifted.

Easy to see



Mouth: wide smile.

Strong



Lift the cheeks; open both arms.

IN THIS STORY

Sam sees his friend return after a long trip.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I am glad you are here!"

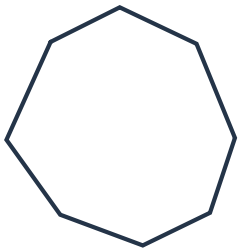
YOUR TURN

Joy may fill the whole body. Draw another cause for this feeling.

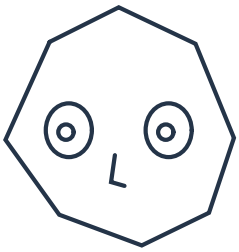
Excited

A class is about to begin its field trip.

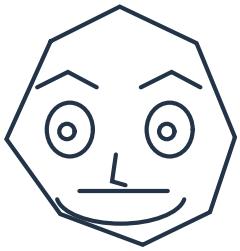
1 Head outline



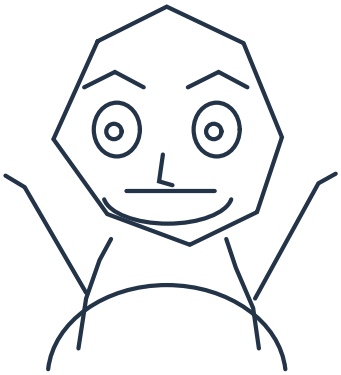
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



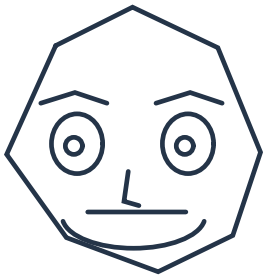
DRAWING CLUE

Open the eyes wider and tilt the body forward.

Excited: three strengths

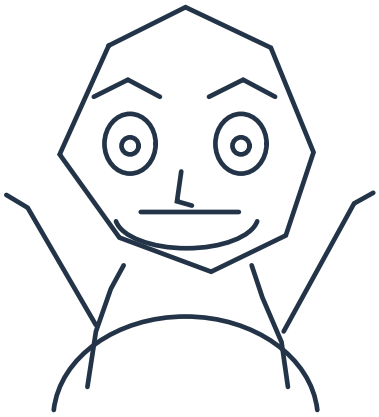
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



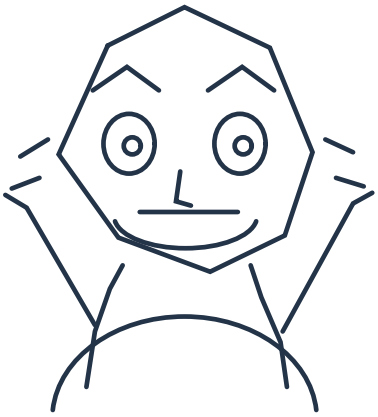
Brow: high.

Easy to see



Mouth: open grin.

Strong



Open the eyes wider and tilt the body forward.

IN THIS STORY

A class is about to begin its field trip.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I can hardly wait to start."

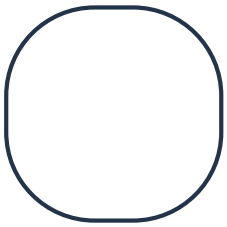
YOUR TURN

Excitement can feel fast and buzzy. Draw another cause for this feeling.

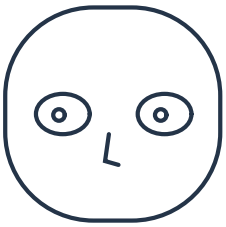
Proud

Nora finally rides her bicycle without help.

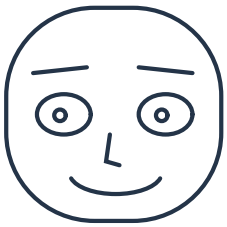
1 Head outline



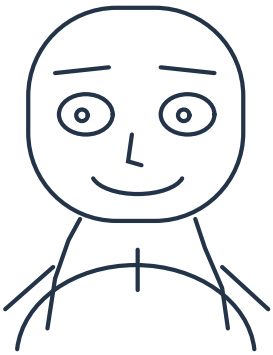
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



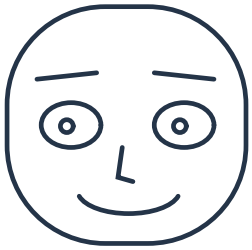
DRAWING CLUE

Keep the chin up and posture tall.

Proud: three strengths

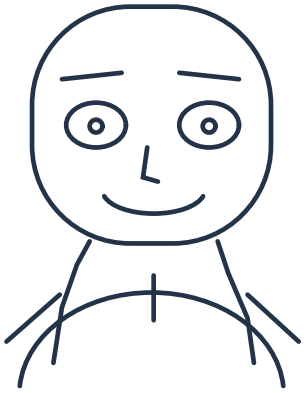
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



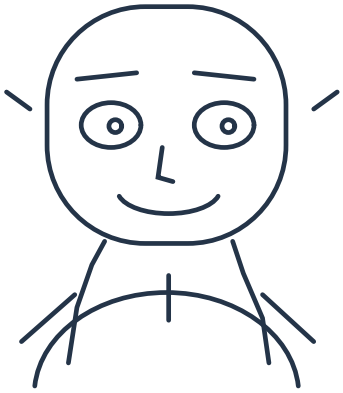
Brow: steady.

Easy to see



Mouth: small smile.

Strong



Keep the chin up and posture tall.

IN THIS STORY

Nora finally rides her bicycle without help.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I worked hard on this."

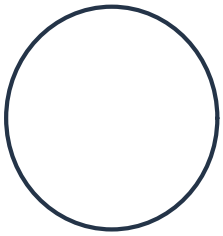
YOUR TURN

Pride can follow patient practice. Draw another cause for this feeling.

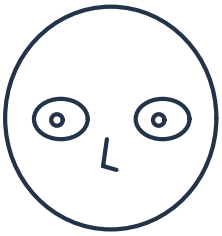
Curious

A box with a strange label arrives.

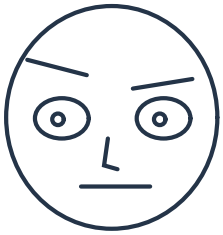
1 Head outline



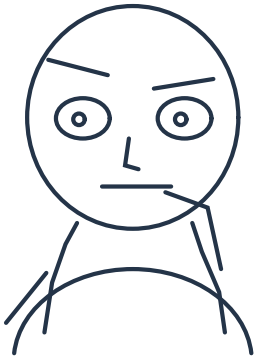
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



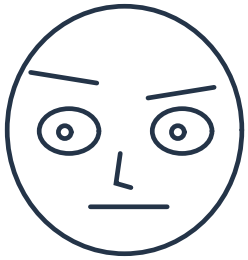
DRAWING CLUE

Raise one brow and turn the head.

Curious: three strengths

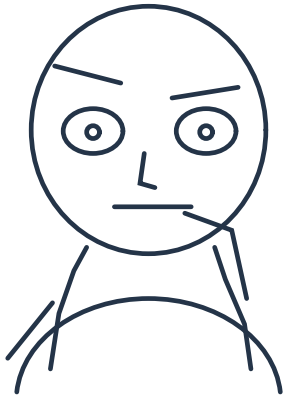
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



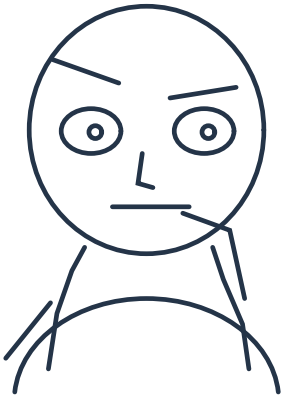
Brow: one up.

Easy to see



Mouth: small open.

Strong



Raise one brow and turn the head.

IN THIS STORY

A box with a strange label arrives.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I wonder how this works."

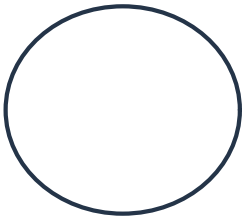
YOUR TURN

Curiosity asks what might be inside. Draw another cause for this feeling.

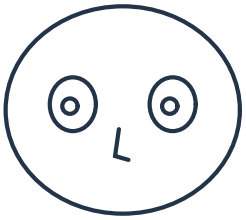
Surprised

A hidden birthday banner drops from the doorway.

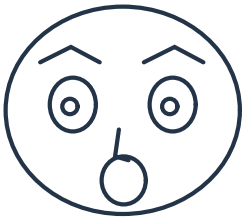
1 Head outline



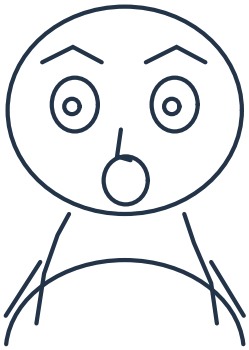
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



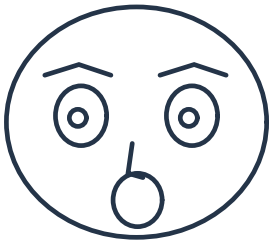
DRAWING CLUE

Lift both brows and make a round mouth.

Surprised: three strengths

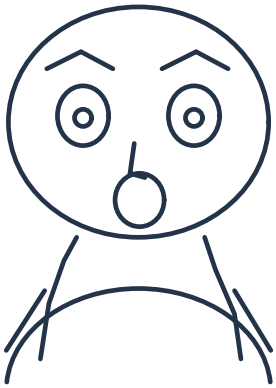
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



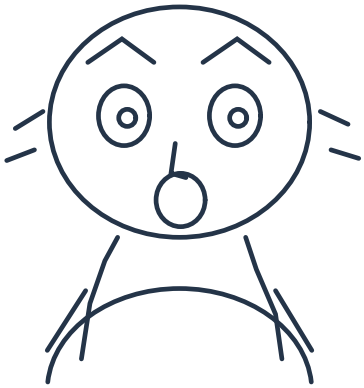
Brow: arched.

Easy to see



Mouth: round.

Strong



Lift both brows and make a round mouth.

IN THIS STORY

A hidden birthday banner drops from the doorway.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Oh! I did not expect that."

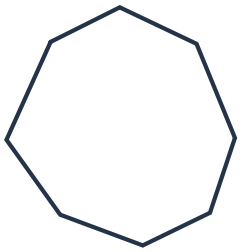
YOUR TURN

Surprise can be pleasant or unpleasant. Draw another cause for this feeling.

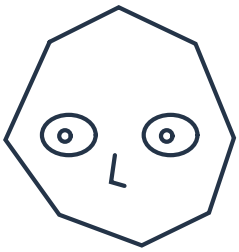
Confused

A map seems to point in two directions.

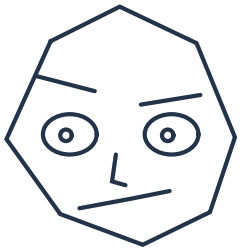
1 Head outline



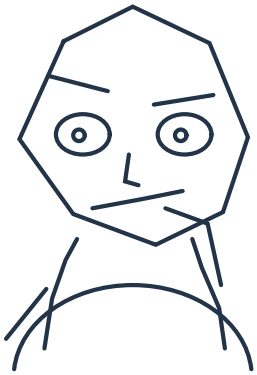
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



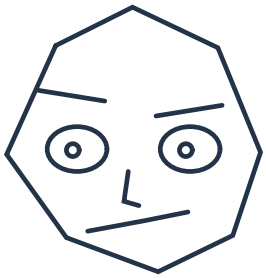
DRAWING CLUE

Make the brows uneven and tilt the head.

Confused: three strengths

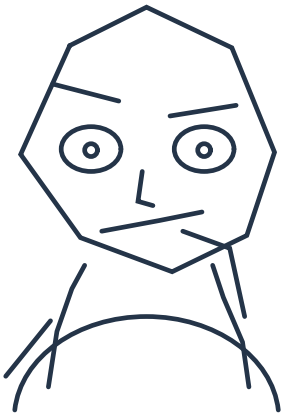
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



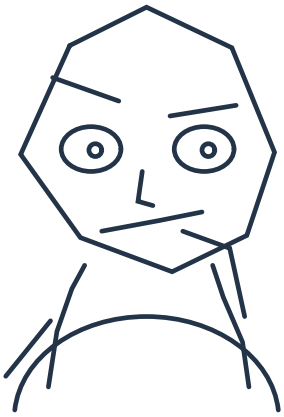
Brow: uneven.

Easy to see



Mouth: crooked.

Strong



Make the brows uneven and tilt the head.

IN THIS STORY

A map seems to point in two directions.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Could you show me another way?"

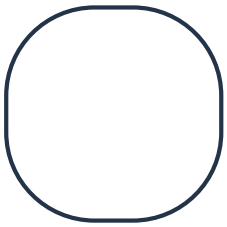
YOUR TURN

Confusion is a cue to ask for help. Draw another cause for this feeling.

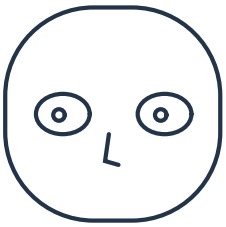
Worried

A late bus has not arrived at the stop.

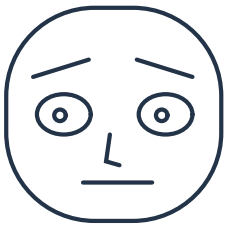
1 Head outline



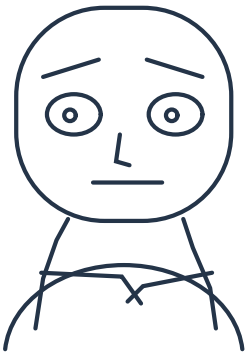
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



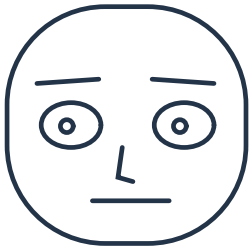
DRAWING CLUE

Lift the inner brows; bring hands together.

Worried: three strengths

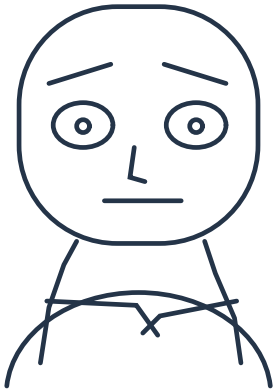
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: inner high.

Easy to see



Mouth: pressed.

Strong



Lift the inner brows; bring hands together.

IN THIS STORY

A late bus has not arrived at the stop.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I hope the bus comes soon."

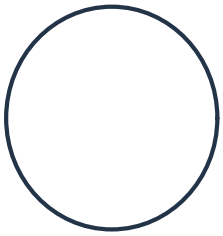
YOUR TURN

Worry is often about what might happen. Draw another cause for this feeling.

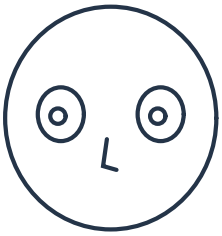
Afraid

A loud thunderclap shakes the windows.

1 Head outline



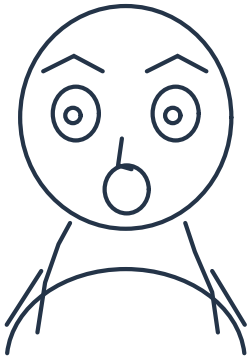
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



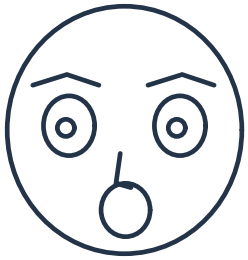
DRAWING CLUE

Widen the eyes; lean the body back.

Afraid: three strengths

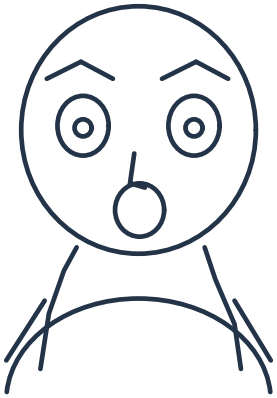
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: high.

Easy to see



Mouth: open small.

Strong



Widen the eyes; lean the body back.

IN THIS STORY

A loud thunderclap shakes the windows.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"That sound startled me."

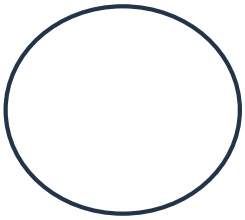
YOUR TURN

A person may also freeze when afraid. Draw another cause for this feeling.

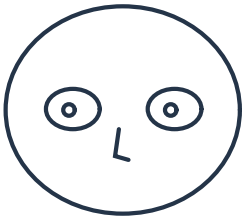
Sad

A favorite toy is broken.

1 Head outline



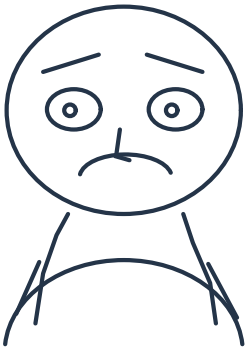
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



DRAWING CLUE

Turn the mouth down and lower the shoulders.

Sad: three strengths

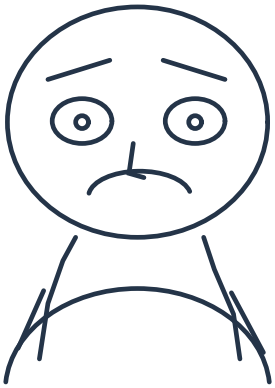
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



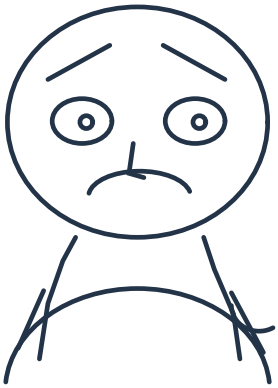
Brow: inner high.

Easy to see



Mouth: down.

Strong



Turn the mouth down and lower the shoulders.

IN THIS STORY

A favorite toy is broken.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I miss how it used to be."

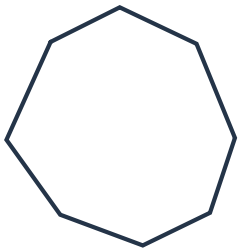
YOUR TURN

Sadness can invite comfort and time. Draw another cause for this feeling.

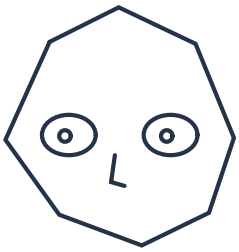
Lonely

Everyone has a partner except Eli.

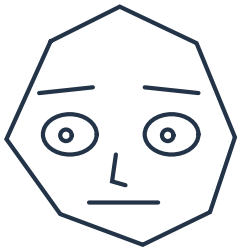
1 Head outline



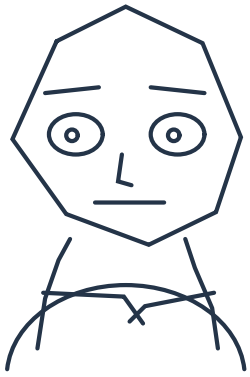
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



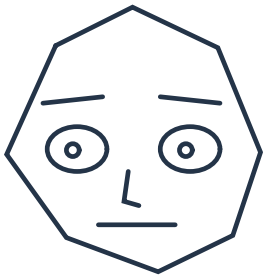
DRAWING CLUE

Look aside; turn the body a little away.

Lonely: three strengths

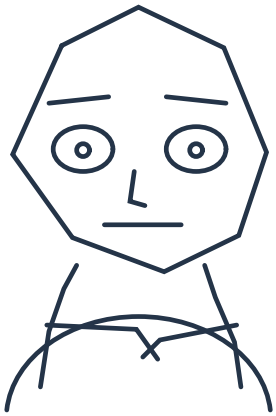
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



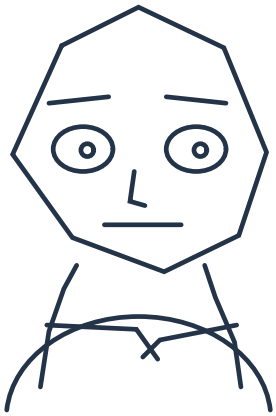
Brow: soft.

Easy to see



Mouth: flat.

Strong



Look aside; turn the body a little away.

IN THIS STORY

Everyone has a partner except Eli.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Could I join you?"

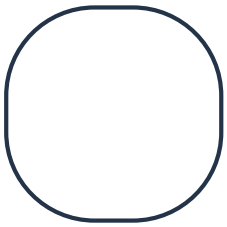
YOUR TURN

Loneliness is about missing connection. Draw another cause for this feeling.

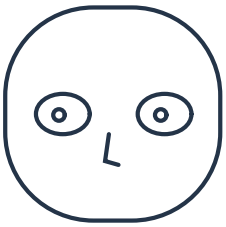
Disappointed

The picnic is canceled because of rain.

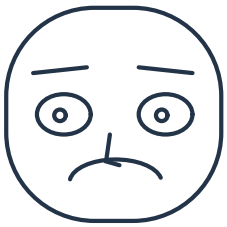
1 Head outline



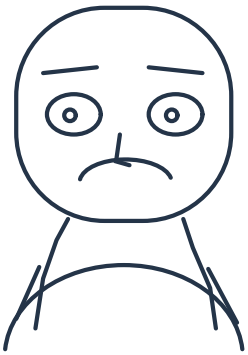
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



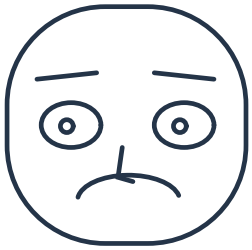
DRAWING CLUE

Let the shoulders sag and the smile fade.

Disappointed: three strengths

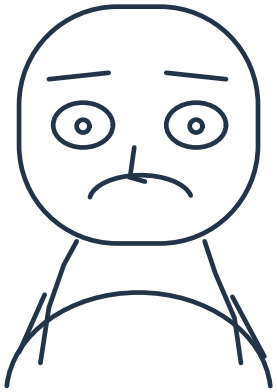
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



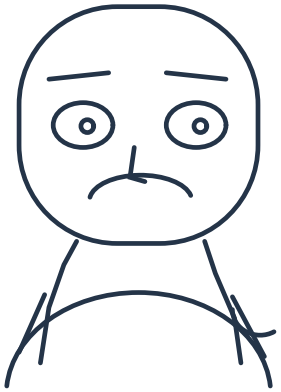
Brow: flat.

Easy to see



Mouth: down small.

Strong



Let the shoulders sag and the smile fade.

IN THIS STORY

The picnic is canceled because of rain.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I was looking forward to that."

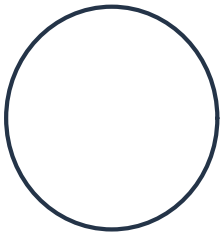
YOUR TURN

Disappointment follows a hoped-for outcome. Draw another cause for this feeling.

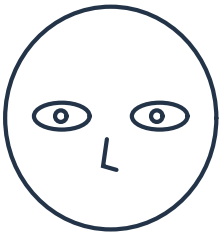
Frustrated

A puzzle piece will not fit after many tries.

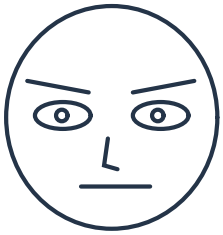
1 Head outline



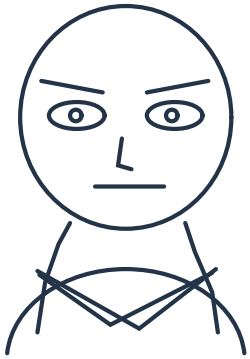
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



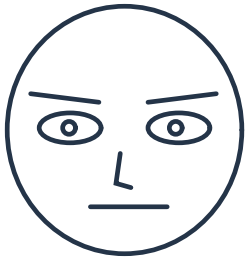
DRAWING CLUE

Angle the brows and tense the hands.

Frustrated: three strengths

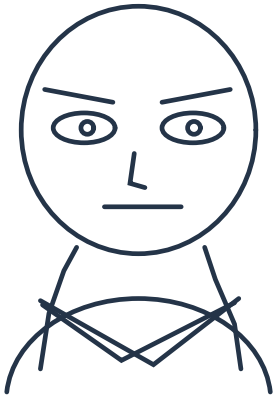
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



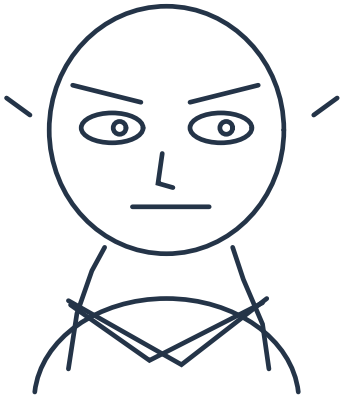
Brow: low.

Easy to see



Mouth: pressed.

Strong



Angle the brows and tense the hands.

IN THIS STORY

A puzzle piece will not fit after many tries.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I need a break before trying again."

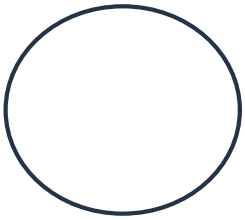
YOUR TURN

Frustration can signal a need for a pause. Draw another cause for this feeling.

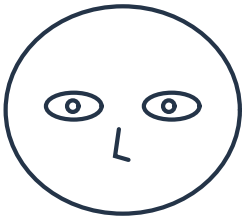
Angry

Someone tears up a drawing without asking.

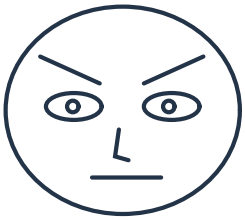
1 Head outline



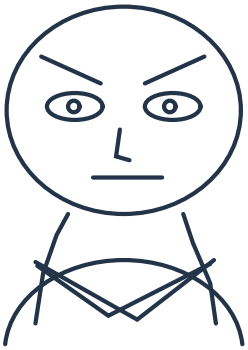
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



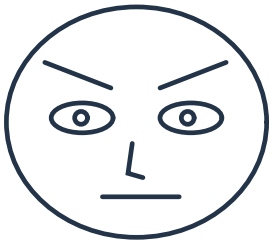
DRAWING CLUE

Lower the brows and square the shoulders.

Angry: three strengths

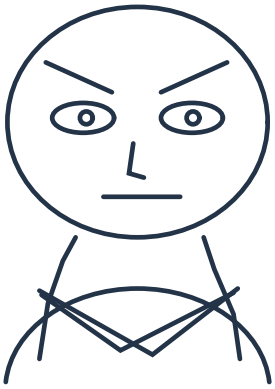
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



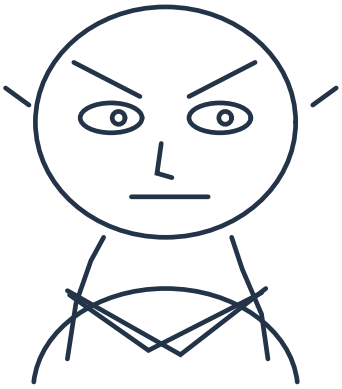
Brow: sharp down.

Easy to see



Mouth: flat hard.

Strong



Lower the brows and square the shoulders.

IN THIS STORY

Someone tears up a drawing without asking.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Please stop. That was mine."

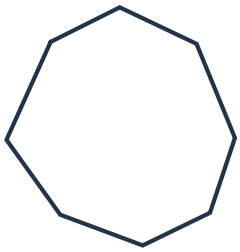
YOUR TURN

Anger is real; actions still matter. Draw another cause for this feeling.

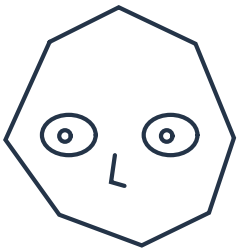
Embarrassed

Tara trips during a quiet assembly.

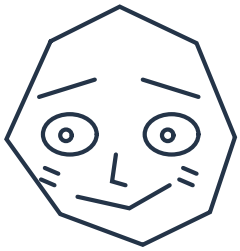
1 Head outline



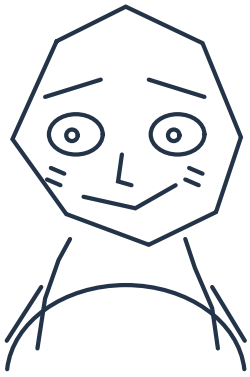
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



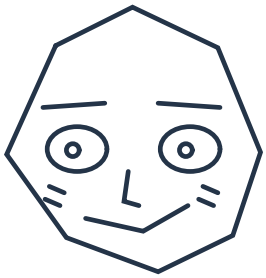
DRAWING CLUE

Add warm cheeks and a hand near the face.

Embarrassed: three strengths

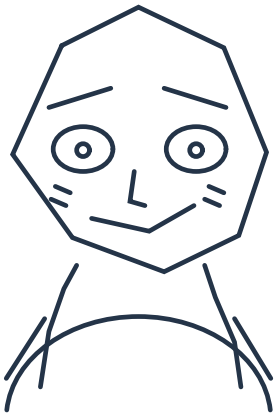
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



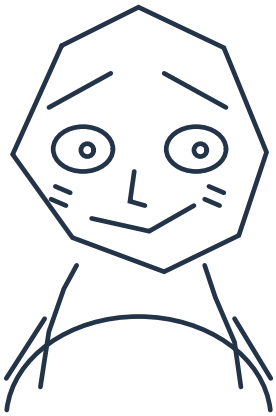
Brow: inner high.

Easy to see



Mouth: uneven smile.

Strong



Add warm cheeks and a hand near the face.

IN THIS STORY

Tara trips during a quiet assembly.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"That was awkward. I am okay."

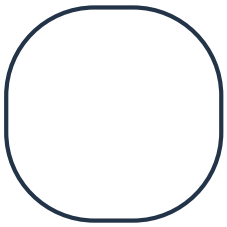
YOUR TURN

Embarrassment may make someone look away. Draw another cause for this feeling.

Shy

A new student is invited to introduce himself.

1 Head outline



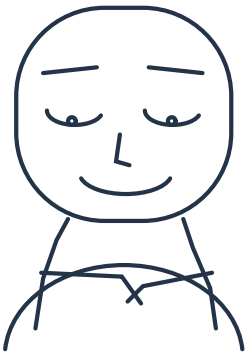
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



DRAWING CLUE

Keep the smile small and arms close.

Shy: three strengths

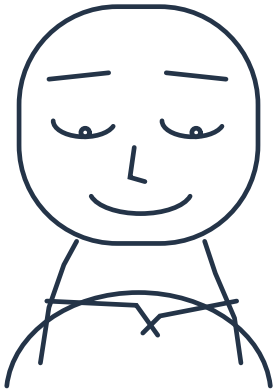
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



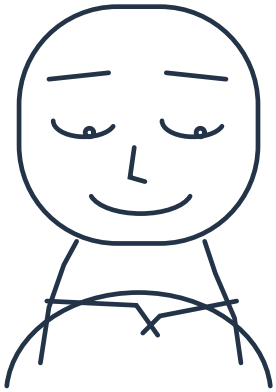
Brow: soft.

Easy to see



Mouth: closed smile.

Strong



Keep the smile small and arms close.

IN THIS STORY

A new student is invited to introduce himself.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Can I go after someone else?"

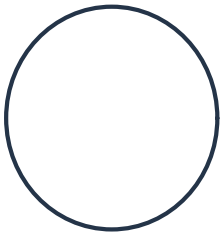
YOUR TURN

A shy person may want more time. Draw another cause for this feeling.

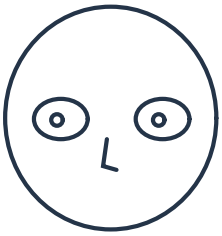
Hopeful

Seeds have been planted in a garden bed.

1 Head outline



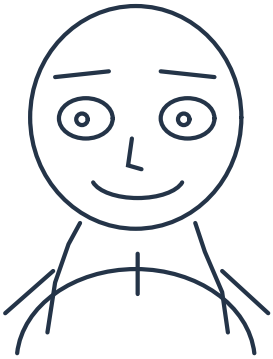
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



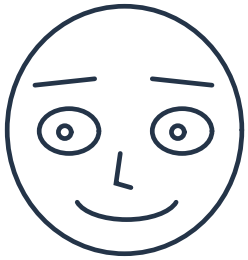
DRAWING CLUE

Lift the gaze slightly toward the future.

Hopeful: three strengths

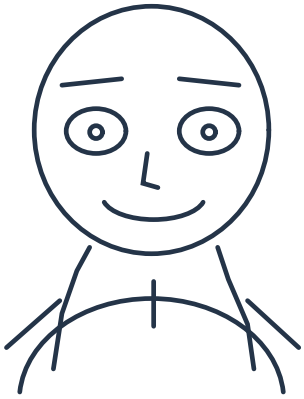
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



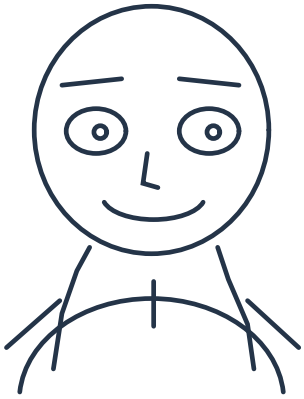
Brow: lifted.

Easy to see



Mouth: small smile.

Strong



Lift the gaze slightly toward the future.

IN THIS STORY

Seeds have been planted in a garden bed.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I think these seeds could grow."

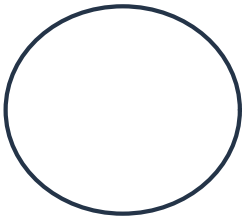
YOUR TURN

Hope looks toward a possible good outcome. Draw another cause for this feeling.

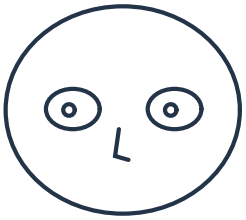
Grateful

A friend helps carry heavy books.

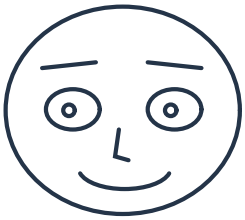
1 Head outline



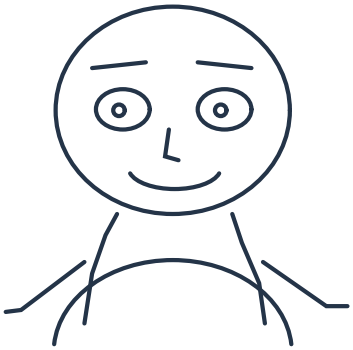
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



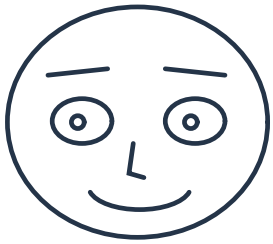
DRAWING CLUE

Relax the eyes; offer an open palm.

Grateful: three strengths

The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



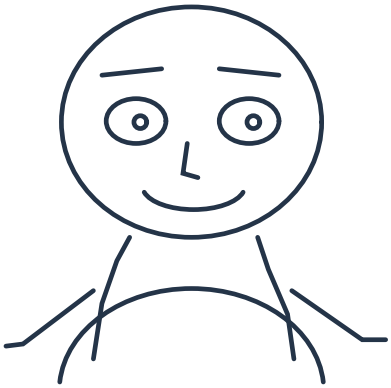
Brow: soft.

Easy to see



Mouth: warm smile.

Strong



Relax the eyes; offer an open palm.

IN THIS STORY

A friend helps carry heavy books.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Thank you for helping me."

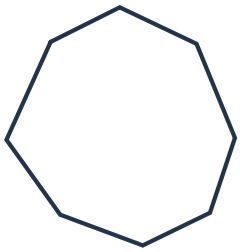
YOUR TURN

Gratitude notices a gift or kindness. Draw another cause for this feeling.

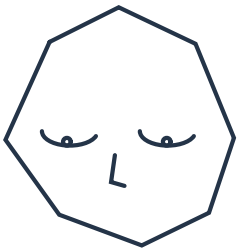
Tired

After a long hike, Jo sits beside the trail.

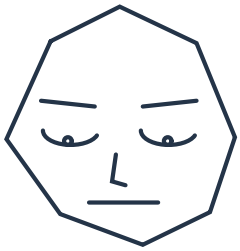
1 Head outline



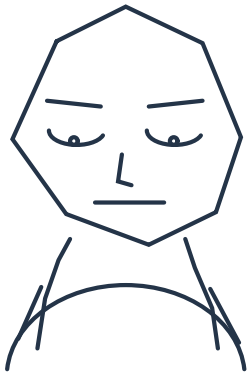
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



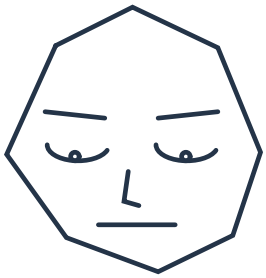
DRAWING CLUE

Lower the eyelids; let the body rest.

Tired: three strengths

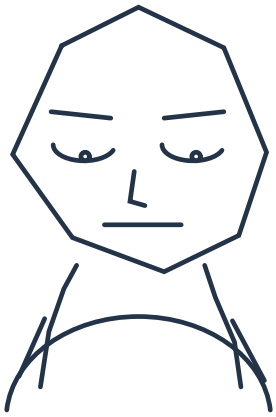
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



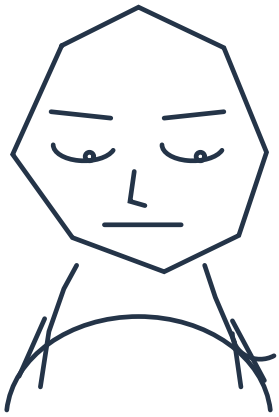
Brow: droop.

Easy to see



Mouth: small flat.

Strong



Lower the eyelids; let the body rest.

IN THIS STORY

After a long hike, Jo sits beside the trail.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I need water and a little rest."

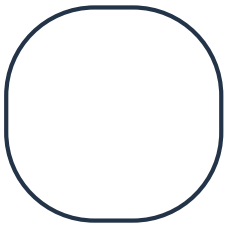
YOUR TURN

Tiredness can look like several feelings. Draw another cause for this feeling.

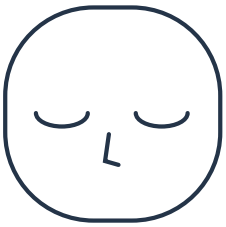
Sleepy

A bedtime story reaches its last page.

1 Head outline



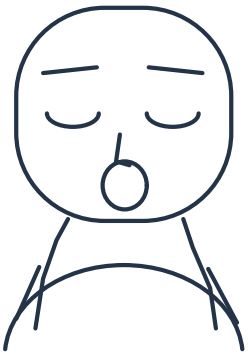
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



DRAWING CLUE

Close the lids and open the mouth in a yawn.

Sleepy: three strengths

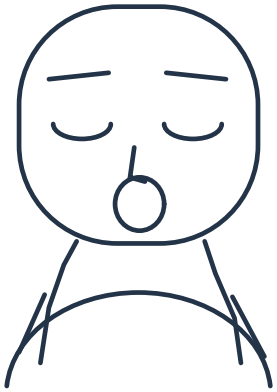
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



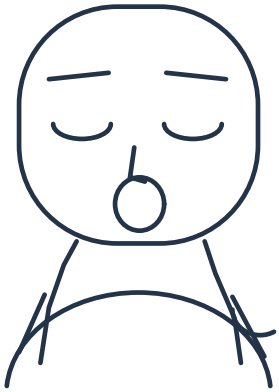
Brow: closed.

Easy to see



Mouth: open yawn.

Strong



Close the lids and open the mouth in a yawn.

IN THIS STORY

A bedtime story reaches its last page.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I am ready to sleep."

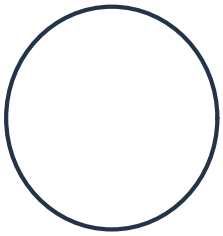
YOUR TURN

Sleepiness is a body cue. Draw another cause for this feeling.

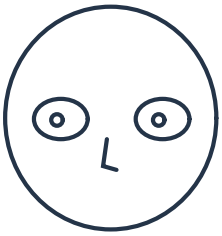
Silly

Two cousins invent an upside-down dance.

1 Head outline



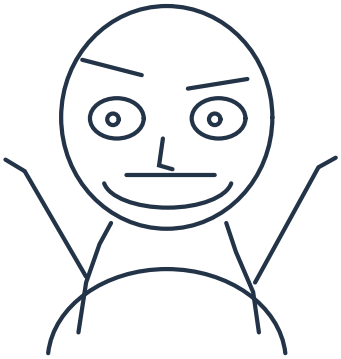
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



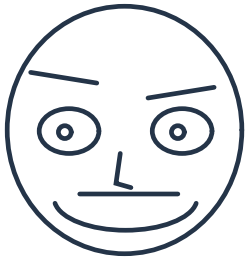
DRAWING CLUE

Make the face asymmetrical and pose playful.

Silly: three strengths

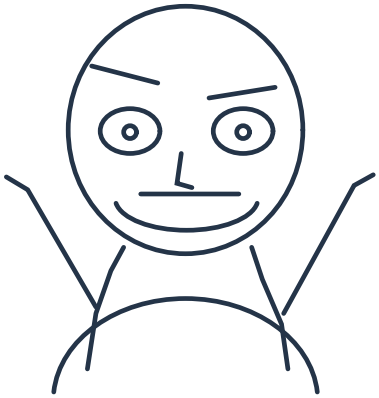
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: one up.

Easy to see



Mouth: side grin.

Strong



Make the face asymmetrical and pose playful.

IN THIS STORY

Two cousins invent an upside-down dance.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Want to try this goofy move?"

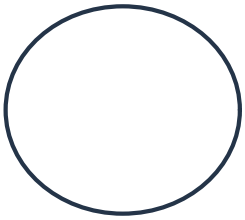
YOUR TURN

Silly can be shared with a willing friend. Draw another cause for this feeling.

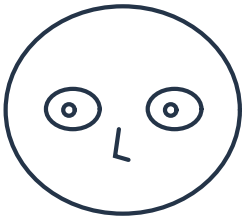
Playful

A puppy brings back a toy for another round.

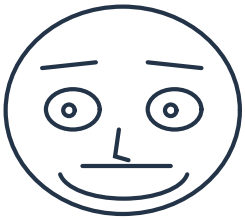
1 Head outline



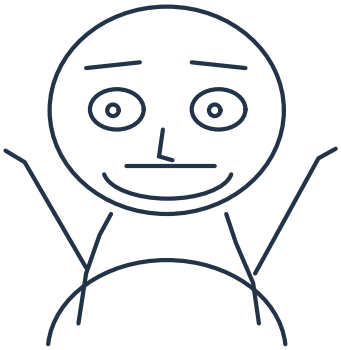
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



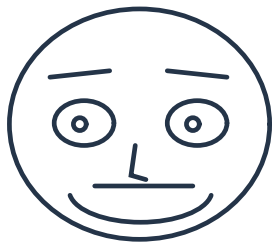
DRAWING CLUE

Let the smile and hands invite a game.

Playful: three strengths

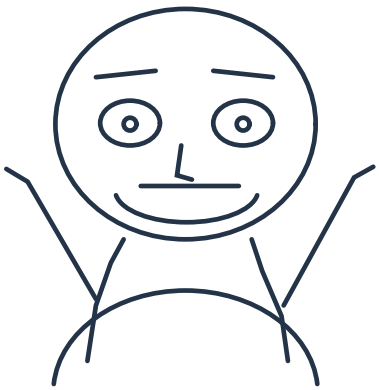
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



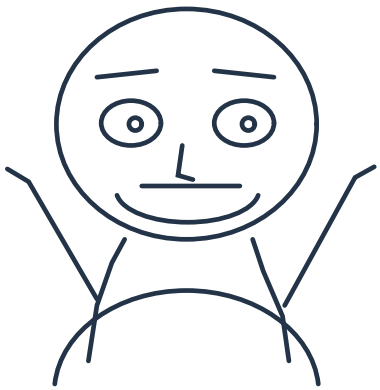
Brow: lifted.

Easy to see



Mouth: open grin.

Strong



Let the smile and hands invite a game.

IN THIS STORY

A puppy brings back a toy for another round.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Let us play again!"

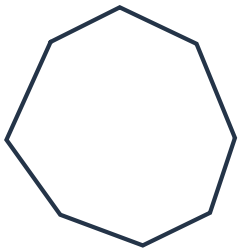
YOUR TURN

Playfulness can be gentle and welcoming. Draw another cause for this feeling.

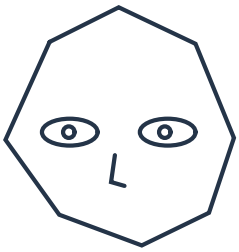
Focused

Ben follows the tiny lines of a drawing.

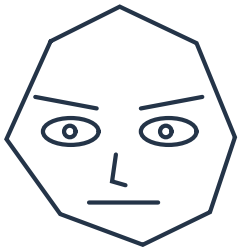
1 Head outline



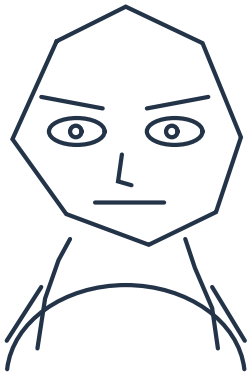
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



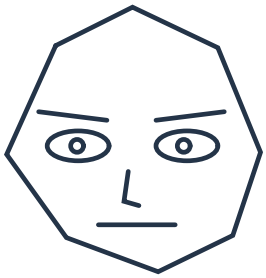
DRAWING CLUE

Aim the eyes at the task; lean in.

Focused: three strengths

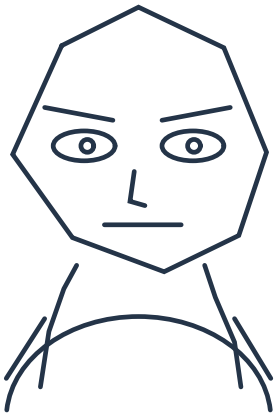
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



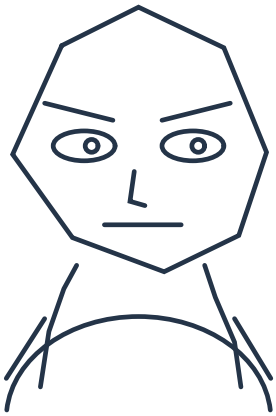
Brow: low flat.

Easy to see



Mouth: neutral.

Strong



Aim the eyes at the task; lean in.

IN THIS STORY

Ben follows the tiny lines of a drawing.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Just a moment; I am finishing this."

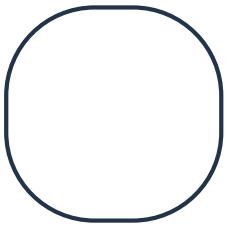
YOUR TURN

Focus may look serious even when enjoyable. Draw another cause for this feeling.

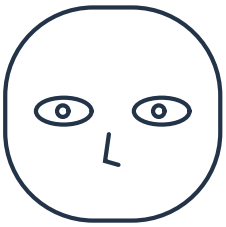
Determined

The hill is steep, but Ada keeps hiking.

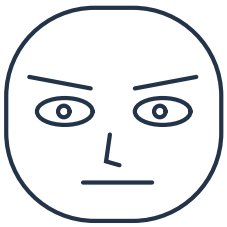
1 Head outline



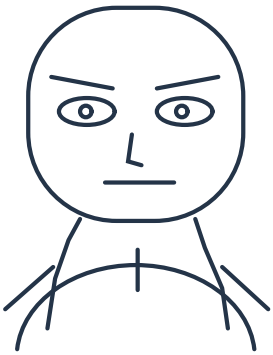
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



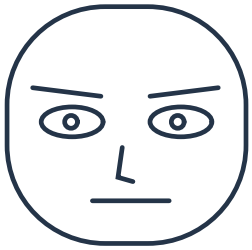
DRAWING CLUE

Set the jaw and keep the body upright.

Determined: three strengths

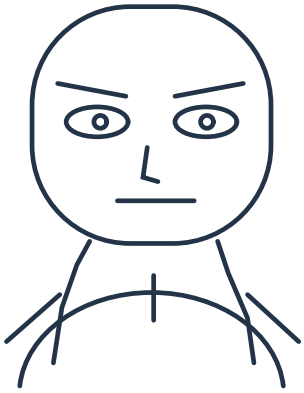
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



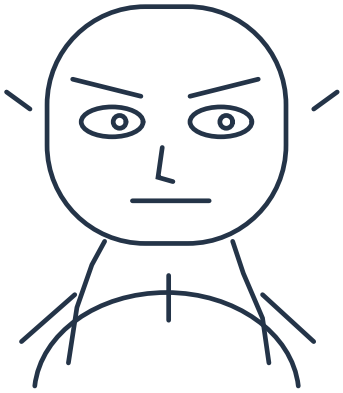
Brow: angled.

Easy to see



Mouth: firm.

Strong



Set the jaw and keep the body upright.

IN THIS STORY

The hill is steep, but Ada keeps hiking.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I will take it one step at a time."

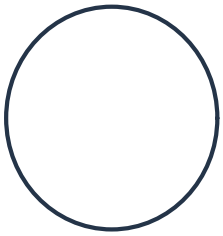
YOUR TURN

Determination means continuing with care. Draw another cause for this feeling.

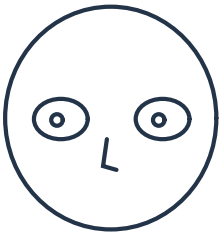
Nervous

It is time to speak in front of the class.

1 Head outline



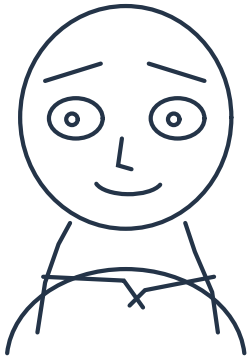
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



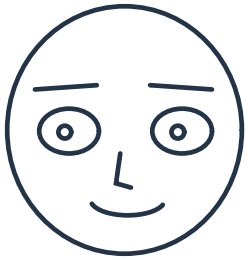
DRAWING CLUE

Show an uncertain smile and hands held close.

Nervous: three strengths

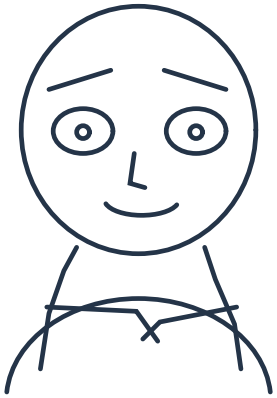
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: inner high.

Easy to see



Mouth: tight smile.

Strong



Show an uncertain smile and hands held close.

IN THIS STORY

It is time to speak in front of the class.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I am nervous, so I will breathe first."

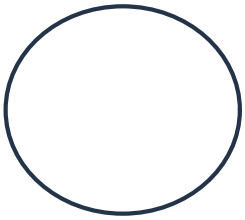
YOUR TURN

Nerves and excitement can appear together. Draw another cause for this feeling.

Relieved

The missing library book is found.

1 Head outline



2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



DRAWING CLUE

Relax the shoulders and draw an exhale.

Relieved: three strengths

The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: soft.

Easy to see



Mouth: exhale.

Strong



Relax the shoulders and draw an exhale.

IN THIS STORY

The missing library book is found.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I am glad we found it."

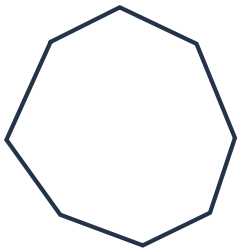
YOUR TURN

Relief follows the end of a worry. Draw another cause for this feeling.

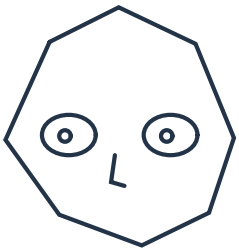
Thoughtful

Lee listens before answering a hard question.

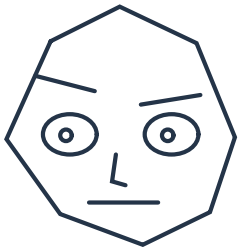
1 Head outline



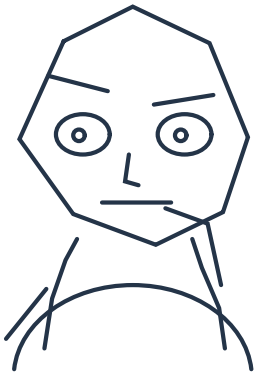
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



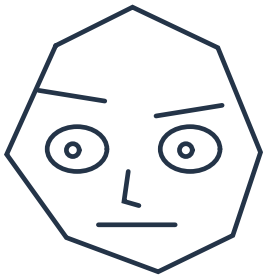
DRAWING CLUE

Look to one side and put a hand near the chin.

Thoughtful: three strengths

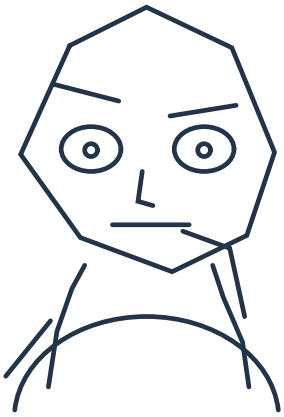
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



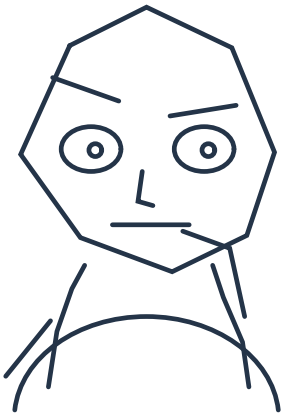
Brow: one up.

Easy to see



Mouth: neutral.

Strong



Look to one side and put a hand near the chin.

IN THIS STORY

Lee listens before answering a hard question.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"Let me consider that."

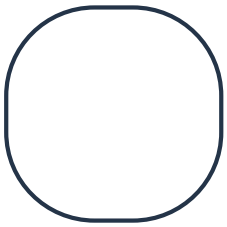
YOUR TURN

Thinking can take time without a clear face. Draw another cause for this feeling.

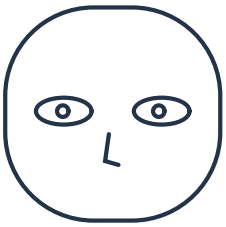
Impatient

The line for the ride has hardly moved.

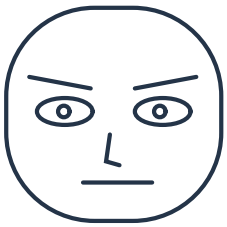
1 Head outline



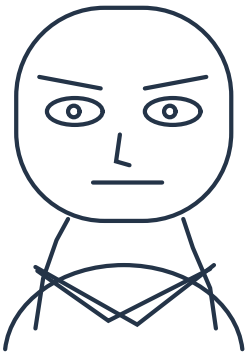
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



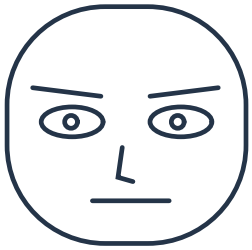
DRAWING CLUE

Tilt the body forward and tap one foot.

Impatient: three strengths

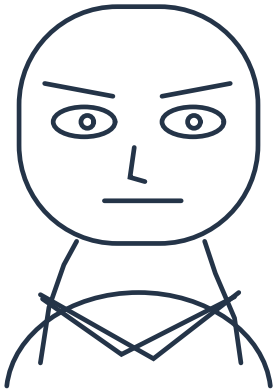
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



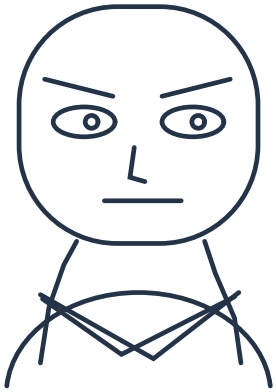
Brow: low.

Easy to see



Mouth: pressed.

Strong



Tilt the body forward and tap one foot.

IN THIS STORY

The line for the ride has hardly moved.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"How much longer will it be?"

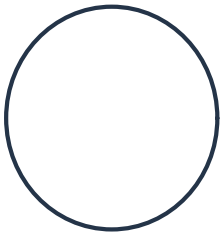
YOUR TURN

Waiting can make the body feel restless. Draw another cause for this feeling.

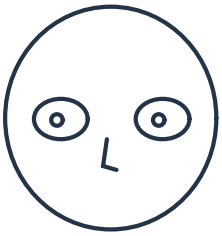
Kind

A child shares an umbrella with a classmate.

1 Head outline



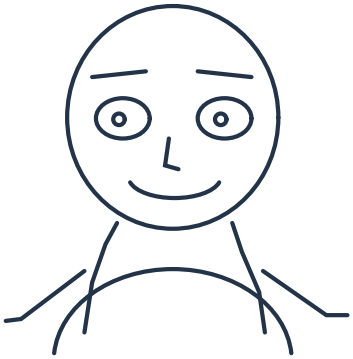
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



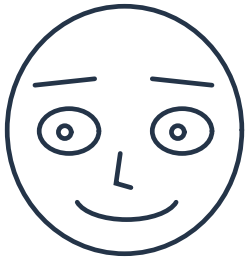
DRAWING CLUE

Use gentle eyes and an open hand.

Kind: three strengths

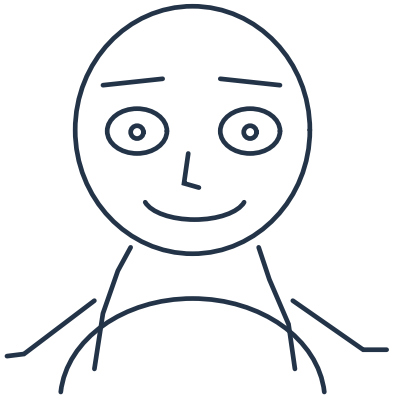
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



Brow: soft.

Easy to see



Mouth: warm smile.

Strong



Use gentle eyes and an open hand.

IN THIS STORY

A child shares an umbrella with a classmate.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"You can stand under here with me."

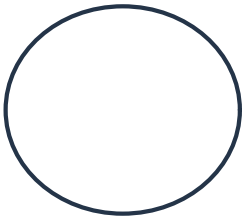
YOUR TURN

Kindness is shown by an action. Draw another cause for this feeling.

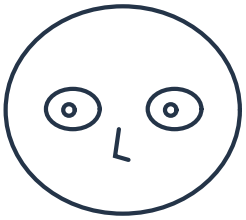
Brave

Rae asks for help when something feels wrong.

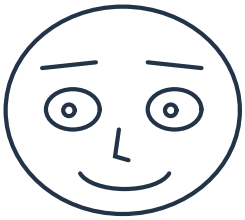
1 Head outline



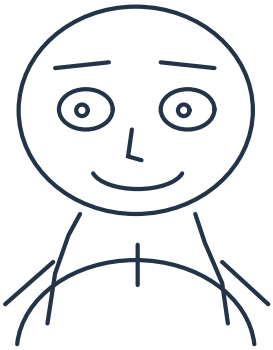
2 Set the eyes



3 Shape brows and mouth



4 Add the body cue



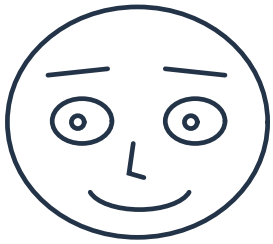
DRAWING CLUE

Keep the posture steady despite worry.

Brave: three strengths

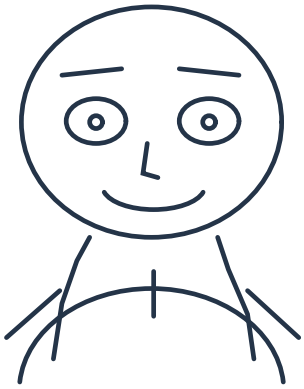
The same feeling can appear softly or strongly.

A hint



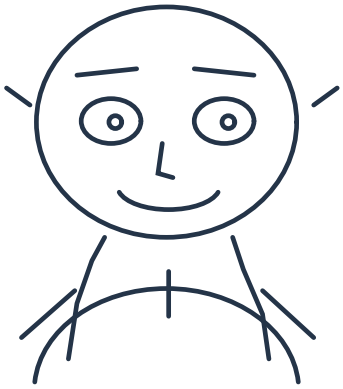
Brow: steady.

Easy to see



Mouth: firm smile.

Strong



Keep the posture steady despite worry.

IN THIS STORY

Rae asks for help when something feels wrong.

A CHARACTER COULD SAY

"I need help with this."

YOUR TURN

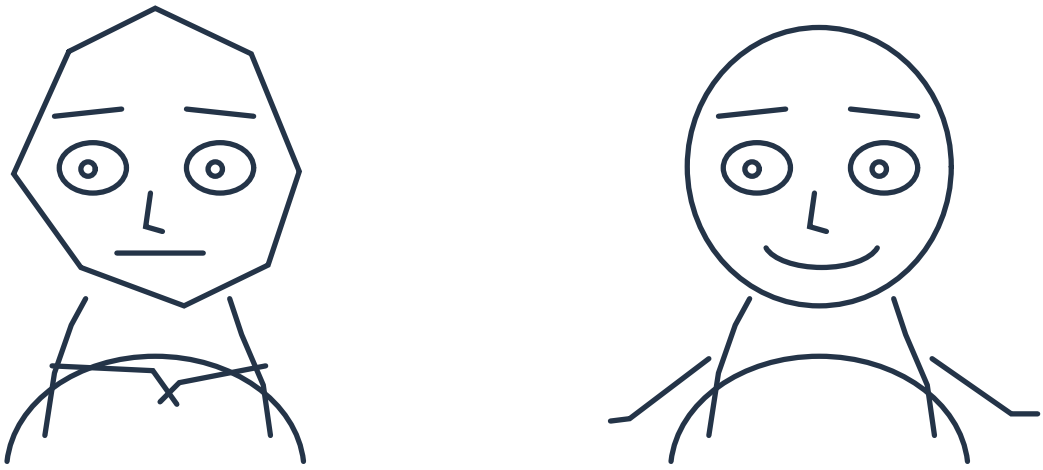
Bravery can happen while afraid. Draw another cause for this feeling.

STORY SCENE 01

A missed invitation

Lonely + Kind

One child notices another sitting alone.



Characters: Lonely and Kind

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

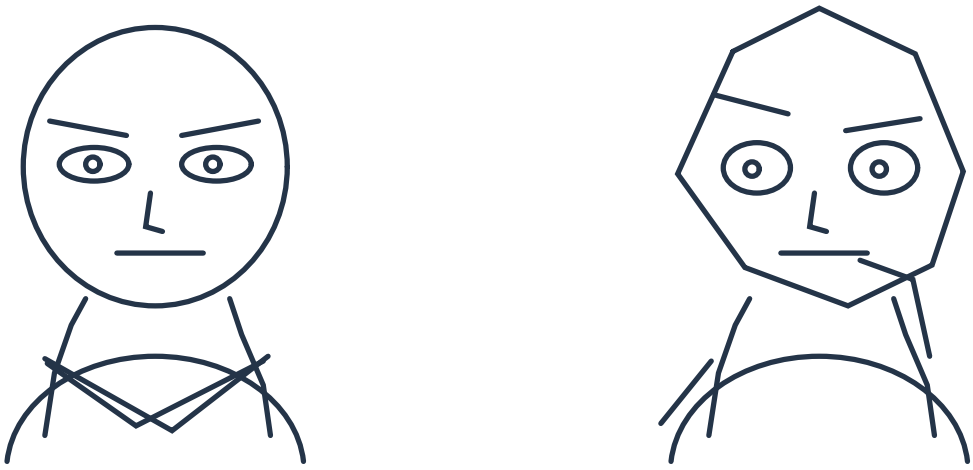
Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 02

The broken project

Frustrated + Thoughtful

A model falls apart just before display time.



Characters: Frustrated and Thoughtful

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 03

A new place

Nervous + Curious

Two children arrive at an unfamiliar club.



Characters: Nervous and Curious

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 04

Waiting for news

Worried + Relieved

The family dog has wandered out and returns.



Characters: Worried and Relieved

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 05

An unexpected gift

Surprised + Grateful

A friend shares something handmade.



Characters: Surprised and Grateful

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

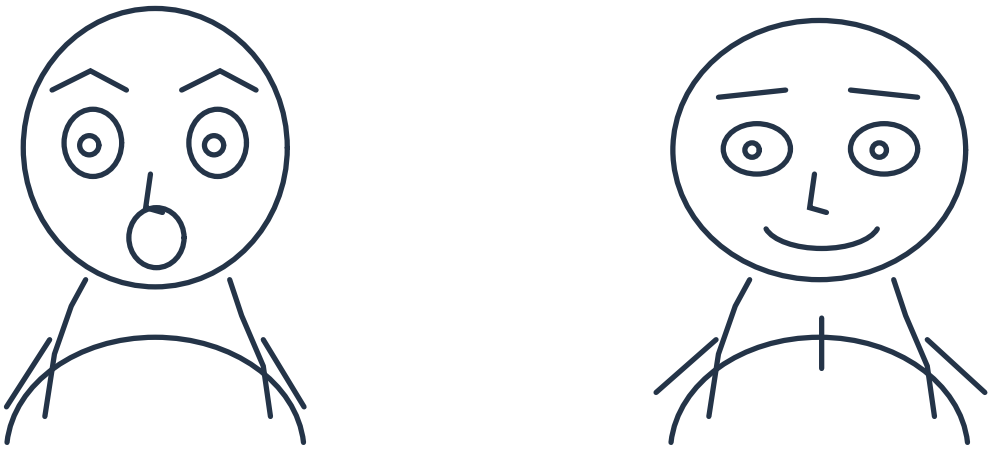
Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 06

The difficult climb

Afraid + Brave

A child asks for help on a steep path.



Characters: Afraid and Brave

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

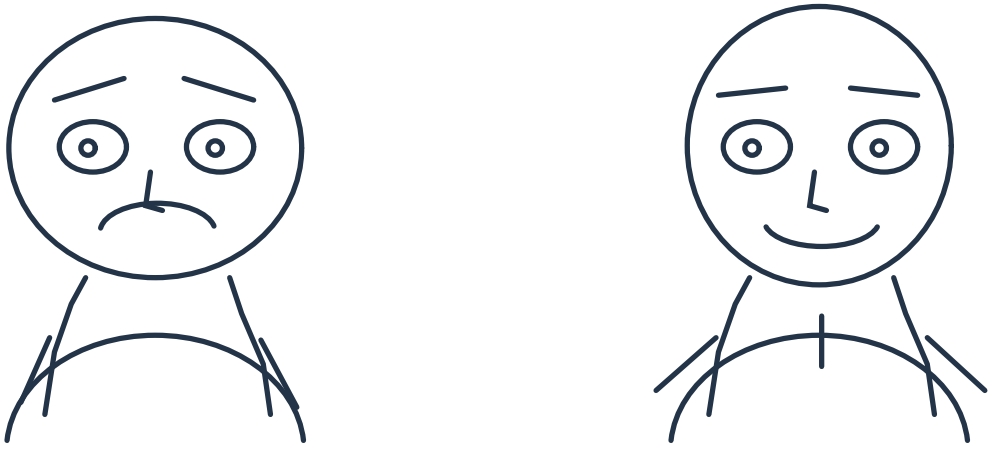
Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 07

A hard goodbye

Sad + Hopeful

Friends promise to write after a move.



Characters: Sad and Hopeful

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

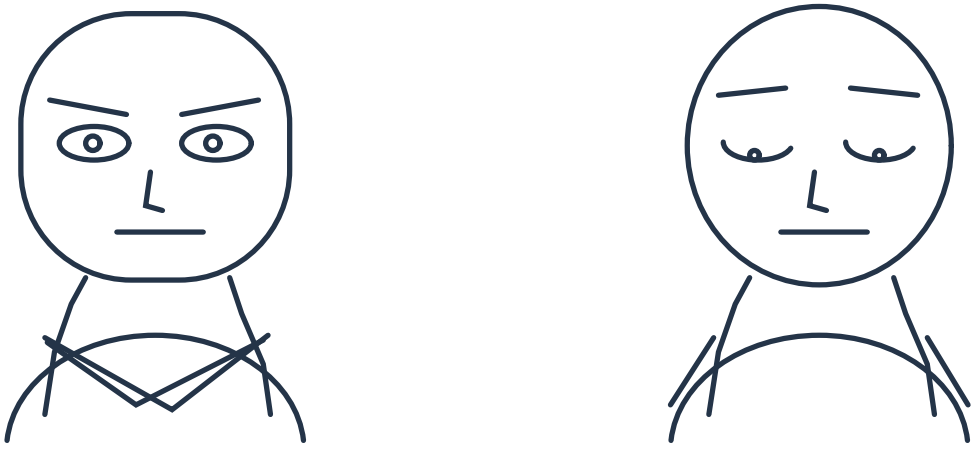
Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 08

Not yet

Impatient + Calm

A long line moves one small step at a time.



Characters: Impatient and Calm

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

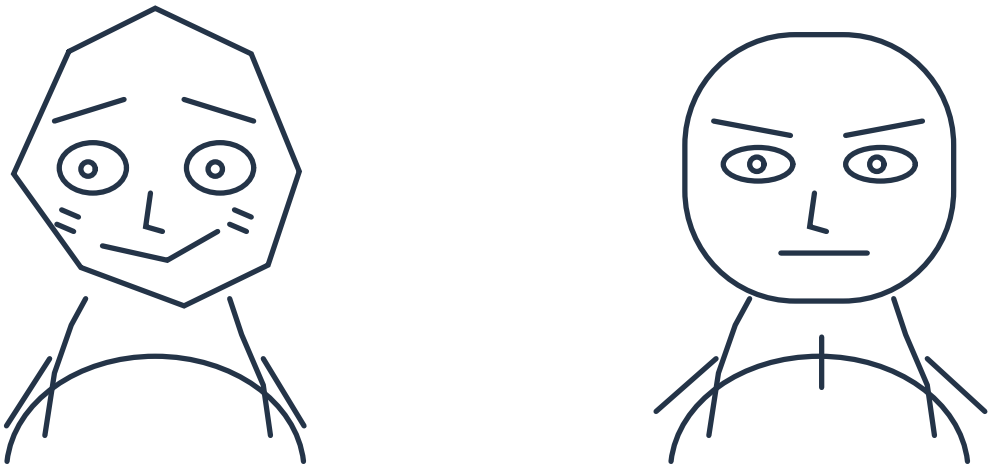
Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 09

A fresh start

Embarrassed + Determined

Someone tries again after a public mistake.



Characters: Embarrassed and Determined

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

Make a bigger version on separate paper.

STORY SCENE 10

Your own story

Joyful + Confused

Choose the story that joins two different feelings.



Characters: Joyful and Confused

1. Show the setting. 2. Add a reason. 3. Draw the next action.

How could each person describe what they feel?

Make a bigger version on separate paper.

REFERENCE

Expression finder

01	Calm	16	Shy
02	Joyful	17	Hopeful
03	Excited	18	Grateful
04	Proud	19	Tired
05	Curious	20	Sleepy
06	Surprised	21	Silly
07	Confused	22	Playful
08	Worried	23	Focused
09	Afraid	24	Determined
10	Sad	25	Nervous
11	Lonely	26	Relieved
12	Disappointed	27	Thoughtful
13	Frustrated	28	Impatient
14	Angry	29	Kind
15	Embarrassed	30	Brave

REFERENCE

When clues are unclear

Look for context

A wide eye can mean fear, surprise, or excitement.

Avoid guessing

Ask kindly when you need to know how someone feels.

Notice change

A small shift in pose can tell part of the story.

Let characters disagree

Two people can feel differently about one event.

FINAL PROJECT

Make your own character

1. Choose an event from your day or invent one.

2. Draw the person before the event and afterward.

3. Change two facial clues and one body cue.

4. Give the person a sentence in their own words.

Your character can feel more than one thing at once.